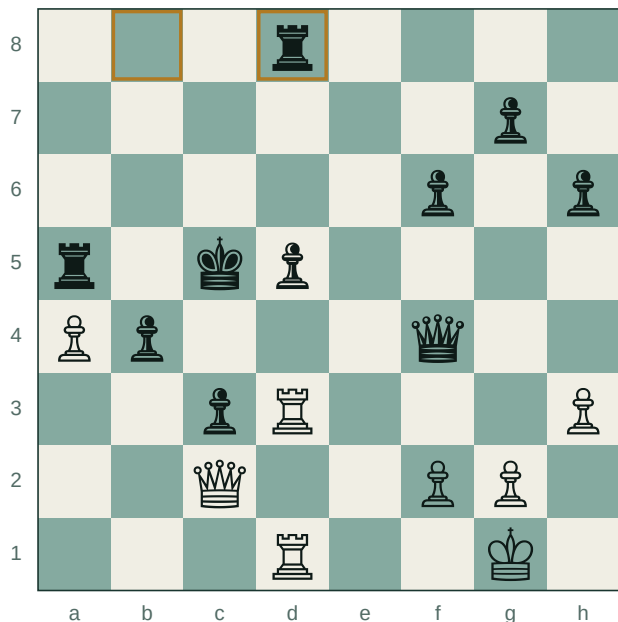


Calculated sacrifices: White, move 40

Calculated sacrifices

White to move



Previous move: 39...Rd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

40. Rxc3+ bxc3 41. Qxc3+ Kd6 42. Qxa5

40.Rxc3+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on c3. Recorded reply: **40...bxc3**.

41.Qxc3+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From c3 it attacks king on c5 and rook on a5. Recorded reply: **41...Kd6**.

42.Qxa5 The queen captures the rook on a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 18 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from -2 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on c5. Absolute pin: pawn on c3.